Obsessive-Compulsive Disorder (DSM-5-TR): Teaching Overview

Clinical Companion Knowledge Library: for counselors and counseling students

1. What it is

Obsessive-compulsive disorder (OCD) involves **obsessions** (unwanted, intrusive thoughts, images, or urges that cause distress) and/or **compulsions** (repetitive behaviors or mental acts done to reduce that distress or prevent a feared outcome). In DSM-5-TR it heads its own chapter, "Obsessive-Compulsive and Related Disorders," separate from the anxiety disorders (American Psychiatric Association [APA], 2022).

How common: in a U.S. national survey, lifetime OCD was 2.3% and 12-month OCD 1.2%. Early onset was more common in men (Ruscio et al., 2010). Across 34 community studies worldwide, lifetime prevalence was 1.3%, and women were about 1.6 times more likely than men to be affected (Fawcett et al., 2020). Without adequate treatment OCD tends to be chronic (Öst et al., 2015).

Counselor framing (general clinical consensus): intrusive thoughts are normal; OCD is maintained by the *meaning* given to them and the rituals used to neutralize them.

2. Core symptoms to watch for

DSM-5-TR criteria, paraphrased (APA, 2022); use the manual itself for formal diagnosis.

- **Obsessions:** recurring, intrusive, unwanted thoughts, urges, or images that cause marked anxiety or distress. The person tries to ignore, suppress, or neutralize them.
- **Compulsions:** repetitive behaviors (washing, checking, ordering, confessing) or mental acts (praying, counting, repeating words, reviewing) the person feels driven to perform in response to an obsession or rigid rules. They aim to reduce distress or prevent a dreaded event but are not realistically connected to it or are clearly excessive.
- **Threshold:** time-consuming (more than about an hour a day) or causing significant distress or impairment. Not due to a substance or medical condition and not better explained by another disorder.
- **Specifiers:** insight is *good or fair*, *poor*, or *absent/delusional beliefs*. Absent insight is still OCD, not psychosis, when the content is OCD-typical. *Tic-related* applies with a current or past tic disorder.
- **Common themes:** contamination, harm and checking, taboo thoughts (sexual, violent, blasphemous), symmetry and "just right."

Scrupulosity (religious or moral OCD): obsessive doubts about having sinned, intrusive blasphemous thoughts, and compulsive religious rituals, reassurance seeking, and avoidance (Abramowitz & Jacoby, 2014). It correlates with inflated responsibility, the need to control thoughts, and **moral thought-action fusion** ("thinking it is as bad as doing it") (Nelson et al., 2006). Compared with other OCD, scrupulous clients were more religious, **more likely to seek pastoral counseling**, and less likely to seek medication. A more negative concept of God went with more severe symptoms (Siev et al., 2011). Among 180 patients, Catholics reported the highest scrupulosity, above Protestant, Jewish, and nonreligious patients (Buchholz et al., 2019). Scrupulous patients also showed higher rates of obsessive-compulsive personality disorder (OCPD), more depression, and a strong link between OCD severity and poor insight (Siev et al., 2021).

Differential tips (general clinical consensus; APA, 2022):

- **GAD:** worries concern real-life problems and feel reasonable. Obsessions feel intrusive and alien and are followed by rituals.
- **Related disorders:** body dysmorphic disorder, hoarding, trichotillomania, and excoriation are separate diagnoses in the same chapter.
- **Psychotic disorders:** absent-insight OCD stays on OCD-typical fears, without hallucinations or formal thought disorder.
- **OCPD:** a lifelong, ego-syntonic pattern of perfectionism and control *without* true obsessions and compulsions. The two can co-occur.
- **Devotion vs. scrupulosity:** healthy practice is chosen, flexible, and shared by one's community. Scrupulous rituals are fear-driven, repeated until they "feel right," and exceed what one's own tradition teaches (Abramowitz & Jacoby, 2014).

Assessment tools:

- **Y-BOCS:** the clinician-rated severity standard. It has 10 items scored 0–40 (Goodman et al., 1989).
- **Self-reports:** the 20-item DOCS covers four symptom dimensions (Abramowitz et al., 2010), and a validated scrupulosity subscale (DOCS-SR) has been added (Wetterneck et al., 2021). The 18-item OCI-R screens with six subscales (Foa et al., 2002).
- **PIOS:** a 19-item scale measuring fear of sin and fear of God's punishment (Abramowitz et al., 2002). In patients it identified scrupulosity best among **Christian** clients (Huppert & Fradkin, 2016).

3. What works: CBT and the evidence

Bottom line for class: CBT built on **exposure and response prevention (ERP)** is the first-line psychological treatment. Cognitive therapy performs about as well, and SSRIs or clomipramine are the medication options.

- **ERP:** planned, repeated contact with feared thoughts or situations while **not** performing compulsions, reassurance seeking, or mental neutralizing. Clients learn that distress fades and can be tolerated.
- **Meta-analytic evidence.** Across 37 RCTs, CBT had very large effects versus waitlist (1.31) and placebo (1.33). ERP and cognitive therapy did not differ, CBT beat antidepressants (0.55), and adding medication to CBT was not significantly better than CBT plus placebo (Öst et al., 2015). An earlier meta-analysis of 16 RCTs (n = 756) found a large post-treatment effect (g = 1.39) (Olatunji et al., 2013). Across 47 studies, response was 70% after treatment and 69% at follow-up (about 2.5 years later on average) (Öst et al., 2026).
- **Landmark trial.** In 122 adults, response rates were 62% for intensive ERP, 70% for ERP plus clomipramine, 42% for clomipramine, and 8% for placebo (Foa et al., 2005).
- **Cognitive therapy.** Intrusions become obsessions when read as meaning one is **responsible** for preventing harm, and neutralizing keeps that belief alive (Salkovskis, 1985). Six belief domains are targeted: inflated responsibility, overimportance of thoughts, need to control thoughts, overestimated threat, intolerance of uncertainty, and perfectionism (Obsessive Compulsive Cognitions Working Group, 1997). *Thought-action fusion* is the belief that a thought is morally equal to an act or makes it more likely (Shafran et al., 1996). Test the *meaning* of thoughts, not their content.
- **ACT and inference-based therapy (brief).** Eight sessions of ACT without in-session exposure beat relaxation training in 79 adults (Twohig et al., 2010). For poor-insight OCD (n = 90), an inference-based approach and CBT were equally effective (Visser et al., 2015).
- **Medication (referral notes).** SSRIs beat placebo across 17 trials (Soomro et al., 2008). In a 54-trial network meta-analysis, clomipramine was not better than SSRIs, and combined treatment was judged likely best in severe OCD (Skapinakis et al., 2016).

4. Religiously integrated CBT for OCD: what the evidence shows

Models. The standard approach keeps ERP intact and adapts it to the client's faith. Treatment weakens rigid beliefs that are *inconsistent with the person's own religion*, builds tolerance of uncertainty, and drops rituals and reassurance (Abramowitz & Jacoby, 2014). Huppert et al. (2007) adapted ERP for ultra-Orthodox Jewish patients by working within religious law and with religious authorities. Himle et al. (2011) reviewed religion and OCD and offered implications for both clinicians and clergy.

Clergy matter. In a survey of 70 Lutheran pastors, those from the more conservative denomination more often endorsed moral thought-action fusion and gave responses that risk reinforcing compulsions, such as urging purity of thought or regular confession of sinful thoughts (Deacon et al., 2013). Storch and Fuselier (2023) call for closer collaboration with clergy in treating scrupulosity.

Treatment studies (all small):

- **ACT for scrupulosity (5 adults, multiple-baseline design):** daily compulsions fell from 25.0 to 5.6 (4.3 at follow-up), and religious faith declined only slightly (Dehlin et al., 2013).
- **Religious CBT (Iran, n = 40):** eight group sessions co-led by a psychiatrist and a clergyman reduced Y-BOCS scores through 6 months. This was a **single-group study with no control**, and patients were also on medication (Aouchekian et al., 2017).
- **Religion-adapted ACT (Iran, n = 36 randomized):** the adapted protocol beat conventional ACT. However, it had 25 sessions versus 8, which confounds the comparison (Dehaghi et al., 2024).
- **CBT group plus religious psychoeducation (n = 23, randomized pilot):** both groups were feasible and improved. Trends favored the integrated group on thought-action fusion; a larger trial is needed (Toprak & Turkcapar, 2026).

Honest summary for teaching:

1. **ERP and cognitive therapy remain the core** for scrupulosity. Religious integration supports acceptability and engagement; it does not replace them.
2. **The evidence is very thin.** We found **no randomized trial of Christian-integrated CBT or ERP for OCD**. Studies are case series, an uncontrolled trial, and small pilots, mostly Muslim samples in Iran or samples of unstated faith.
3. **Practice ethics (general consensus):** integrate faith only with consent and after a spiritual assessment. Get ERP training or supervision, and refer when needed.

5. Practical Christian-integration notes

These apply Dr. Campbell's **identify, challenge, replace-with-Scripture** method. *Clinical* items rest on the research above. *Pastoral* items are theological application, not research findings.

- **Identify (clinical).** Map the cycle: intrusion, then appraisal ("this thought means I am wicked"), then ritual (re-praying, confessing, checking), then brief relief, then more doubt. Call OCD OCD, not spiritual failure.
- **Challenge (clinical).** Challenge the *appraisal* (moral thought-action fusion, inflated responsibility, need for certainty), not whether a sin occurred. Debating content becomes reassurance.
- **Replace (pastoral).** State identity and grace *once*, not as a repeated ritual: Romans 8:1, 1 John 3:20, Psalm 103:13–14, and Ephesians 2:8–9 (grace, not works). Matthew 6:7 (no "empty phrases") can frame repeated-prayer compulsions.
- **Faith-consistent ERP (clinical).** Examples: praying once without "redoing it," reading a feared passage without reviewing, allowing a blasphemous intrusion without neutralizing, and keeping confession to the church's ordinary practice. With a signed release, ask the pastor to answer once and then decline repeated reassurance.

- **Ministers:** use this for **referral awareness only**; refer suspected OCD to a licensed clinician trained in ERP.

6. Quick classroom takeaways

- Diagnose by time (about an hour a day) or impairment; specify insight and tic history; screen for scrupulosity.
- **ERP and cognitive therapy** are first-line with large, durable effects. SSRIs or clomipramine are options, and combined treatment helps severe cases.
- **Faith-integrated ERP** is promising but thinly studied, with no Christian-specific trial. Keep response prevention at the core.

Sources note

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